Chapter 4

On "Hammerklavier", Movement 1

4.1 Introduction

Moving on to Beethoven's Op. 106 "Hammerklavier," this piece is also particularly notable for its striking opening theme—a 'Fanfare' motto that, despite appearing only a few times, forms the thematic core of the entire work.

Vincent d'Indy provides a comprehensive walkthrough of this sonata from beginning to end, making it the only full piece he discusses in detail within the initial movement section of his chapter. This choice emphasizes an example-driven methodology in d'Indy's approach. Similarly, Caplin offers a complete analysis of another work—Beethoven's Op. 2 No. 1—to outline his theory. Interestingly, the two scholars chose pieces from opposite ends of Beethoven's compositional spectrum: d'Indy analyzes one of Beethoven's latest and most complex works, while Caplin uses one of his earliest sonatas. The Hammerklavier is a large-scale piece with an intricate fugal texture in its development, making it a challenging candidate for any analytical theory, while Op. 2 No. 1 is much smaller in scale and adheres more closely to classical conventions. Consequently, d'Indy's theory adequately handles the degree complexities of the Hammerklavier, whereas Caplin's theory underfits when applied to such monumental works, revealing its limitations in analyzing more complex movements like the Hammerklavier.

Similar to the main theme in Beethoven's 5th Symphony, Caplin's theory encounters challenges and paradoxes when trying to label the main theme of the Hammerklavier. There is justification for both interpretations: either including the opening measures as part of the theme, which results in a theme with disproportionate phrasal lengths, or treating the initial measures as an introduction, which preserves a more balanced internal structure within the theme. In contrast, d'Indy's theory, with its emphasis on genesis of musical idea, handles this ambiguity more effectively, providing a more adaptive solution for cases where themes are particularly distinct or prominent.

Contrary to d'Indy's unconventional label in his analysis of the development section in Beethoven's 5th Symphony, it is now Caplin who introduces an unconventional form label in the Hammerklavier Sonata, challenging the scholarly consensus. Previously, d'Indy's analysis diverged from established interpretations, but for this piece, his reading aligns more closely with conventional views, whereas Caplin's interpretation breaks away. Examining these ambiguities in form labeling further reveals how each scholar's distinct methodological approach influences their interpretation.

D'Indy's theory of genesis offers certain advantages over Caplin's functional approach by providing more internal consistency when dealing with ambiguous formal boundaries. Moreover, d'Indy's example-driven methodology on a complex piece like the Hammerklavier enables him to address problematic formal divisions more effectively. Ultimately, this chapter will further demonstrate how these theoretical distinctions influence their analytical outcomes and impact our broader understanding of Beethoven's formal structures.

4.2 Comparative Analysis on the Main Theme

4.2.1 D'Indy's Analysis

The main theme, or the first idea (A) is marked by a strong affirmation of the tonic key, which is a common feature in Beethoven's compositions. D'Indy notes that Beethoven frequently begins his pieces with vigorous and repeated tonic chords, establishing a clear tonal center from the outset. In Op. 106, the initial rhythmic cell is primarily tonal and rhythmic, giving the first idea a decidedly masculine character. Despite the presence of secondary or complementary periods that may exhibit a more melodic quality, the overall thematic unity is maintained through the consistent use of this initial rhythmic cell.

This main theme exemplifies a case where cells are contained within a generative period, a standard organization of formal units as discussed in earlier in section 2.4, contrasting with the example in section 3.2.1. This arrangement also serves as a powerful tool for resolving inconsistencies in Caplinian approaches when applied to this main theme section.

It is important to note that, according to d'Indy, there are two generative periods suggested, and the period following the second generative period is referred to as a secondary period. Thus, the interpretation could be that d'Indy treats repetition, such as the statement-response repetition in this case (which is not an exact repetition), as not influencing the order of subsequent events.[1] Similar to his analysis on Beethoven's Symphony No. 5 as in 3.3, d'Indy's observation illustrates how d'Indy's judgment is guided by homogeneity, treating materials with homogeneous content as a single entity.

Given that d'Indy has not provided annotation for the content following measure 8, there is ambiguity in annotating the subsequent section as either a third period or repeating the second period, considering d'Indy's insensitivity to repetition. For the sake of convenience and logical consistency, where the second would logically be followed by a third, I label m. 10 as the beginning of the third period in Fig. 4.3.

[1] Exact repetition and statement-response repetion are Caplinian terms [Caplin, 2013, pp.41-4].

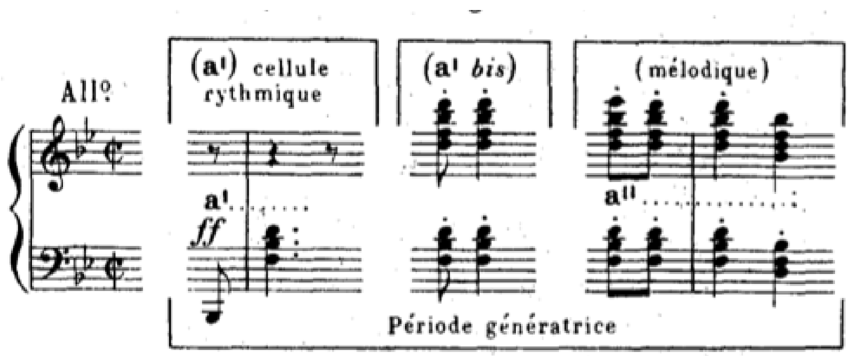

Figure 4.1: mm. 1-4 treated as two rhythmic cells, contained in by a generative period [d'Indy, 1909, p. 236].

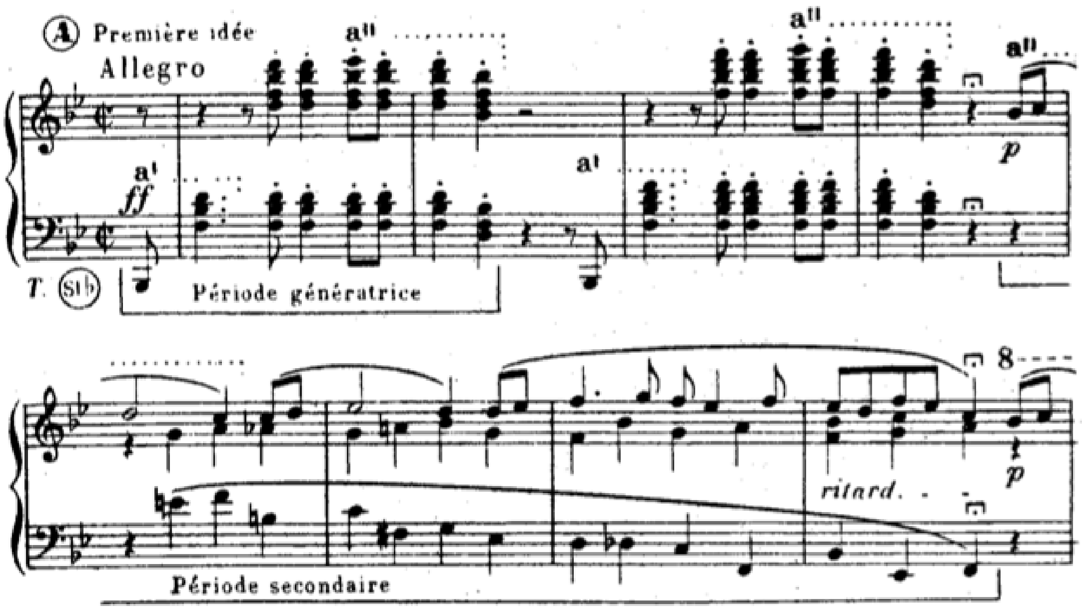

Figure 4.2: D'Indy's analysis on the opening measures[d'Indy, 1909, p. 264].

4.2.2 Caplinian Analysis

Similarly, there is ambiguity in labeling the opening four measures as the presentation phrase of the main theme or as other elements, such as a thematic introduction.

Labeling the opening measures as a thematic introduction poses challenges because the "fanfare" motto is so distinctive in the piece, despite not occurring frequently. It is precisely this motive that has led to the piece being recognized and titled as the "Hammerklavier." This motive is also relatively more thematic compared to the subsequent passage, which, due to the contrast, does not possess thematic importance. Moreover, m. 5 begins on a dominant harmony, further weakening its thematic claim.

Similar to the paradox of Caplin's analysis on Beethoven's 5th Symphony, there are two ways to interpret it within the Caplinian framework, of which the first one, labeled as "Caplin 1" in Fig. 4.3, consists of treating the opening four measures as the presentation, with the following measures serving as the continuation, leading to a half cadence in m. 8. Following the half cadence, the continuation returns using the "one more time" technique, extending further to reach a perfect authentic cadence (PAC) in m. 17.

However, considering the relationship between the two cadences and the homogeneity of materials beginning in m. 5 and m. 9, it suggests a periodic theme type with an expanded consequent. This analysis, labeled as "Caplin 2" in 4.3, maintains a more balanced structure.[2] The half cadence on m. 8 leaves the preceding phrase with unresolved tension, necessitating a **response** rather than a simple "one more time" restatement, which would fail to convey the sense of closure and balance expected from a well-formed period. Labeling m. 9 as the start of a consequent phrase suggests that the tension created by the half cadence in m. 9 is resolved, following the call-and-response dynamic typical of a periodic structure.

4.2.3 Comparison

We observed challenges in applying Caplin's theory, particularly regarding harmonic syntax. The harmonic rhythm of the main theme is relatively high and dense compared to classical repertoire, with 3–4 chords per measure throughout mm. 5–17. This characteristic aligns with Caplin's description of Romantic music, as discussed in [Caplin, 2018], which he describes as having a uniform harmonic rhythm and density, and increased use of chromaticism and dissonance. This even

[2] Using the annotation style suggested in [Hentschel et al., 2024], which allows for the concurrent representation of multiple analyses on the same piece.

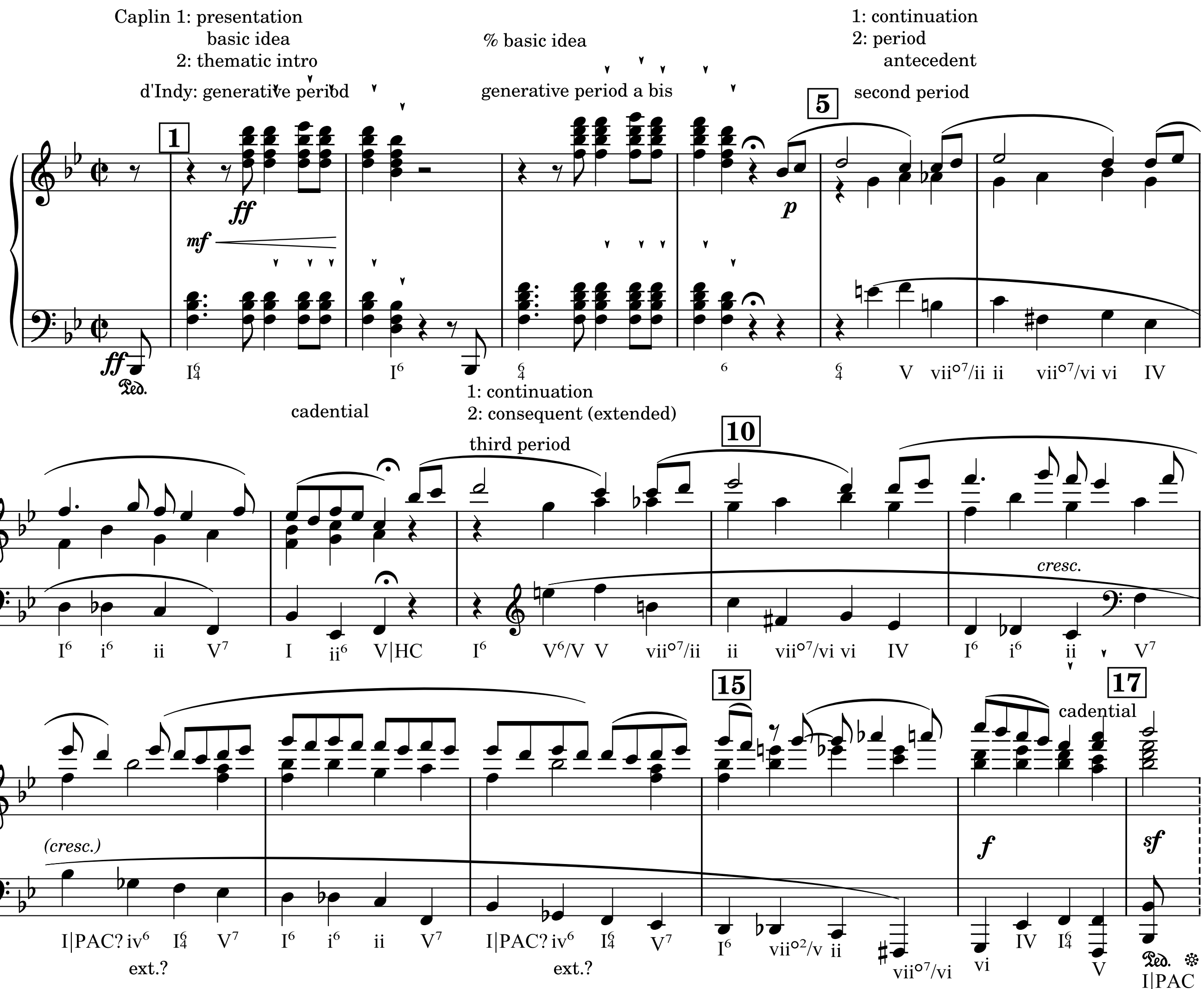

Figure 4.3: Caplin's and d'Indy's analyses of the main theme of op. 106, no. 1.

density complicates the distinction between cadential and post-cadential material, creating ambiguity as to whether measures 13 and 15 should be treated as abandoned cadences with extensions. As a result, Caplin's harmonic rules do not fully apply here. Instead, the basis for grouping defers to parallelism rather than Caplin's preferred harmonic syntax, shifting the analysis closer to d'Indy's perspective.

While Caplin's analysis similarly features a nested structure, d'Indy's analysis here presents a flatter configuration, interpreting the main theme section as a succession of three periods. This perspective introduces certain limitations. As discussed earlier in Campos's critique of d'Indy's tendency to exagerate the role of generation, d'Indy here places perhaps too much emphasis on the generative period. His discussion primarily centers on thematic resemblance between the generative period and the subsequent second and third periods. In contrast, Caplin's analysis incorporating antecedent and consequent highlights a statement-response relationship between what d'Indy refers to as the second and third periods. Rather than relying on a single source or origin, considering materials as emerging from a succession of references, each building on the previous one, would yield a more constructive analysis.

4.3 On Where Begins the Subordinate Theme

4.3.1 D'Indy's Analysis

D'Indy's analysis places significant emphasis on the transition (P), dividing it into three distinct elements. He acknowledges that this transition is notably longer and more complex than in many of Beethoven's earlier works. The initial element of the transition (mm. 18-34) is derived from the rhythmic cell of the first idea, ending with a dominant pedal on m. 31, shown in 4.4. The second element (mm. 35-45) uses the generative period to modulate to the dominant of the relative key, G major, with some modal mixture, shown in 4.5. The final element (mm. 45-63), shown in 4.6, is a long melodic line over the dominant of the new key, preparing for the introduction of the second idea [d'Indy, 1909, pp.265-8].

The second idea (B) in Beethoven's exposition is characterized by its melodic, insinuating, and supple nature, which stands in contrast to the more rhythmic and assertive first idea. D'Indy explains that the second idea generally consists of three distinct but interrelated phrases.

The first expository phrase (mm. 65-74), shown in 4.7, is derived from a melodic cell of the first idea and consists of three periods in G major [d'Indy, 1909, p. 269]. This phrase sets the stage for the second idea, maintaining thematic continuity.

The complementary phrase (mm. 75-99), shown in 4.8 also subdivides into three periods. The first phrase resolves on the dominant, the second shifts toward the subdominant and is followed by an episodic recall of the cell (a'') from the initial idea (A), and the third phrase returns to the tonic [d'Indy, 1909, pp.270-1].

A third conclusive phrase (mm. 100-120), shown in 4.9, remaining on the tonic harmony, is also composed of three periods, where the first two being directed towards the subdominant and forming a double plagal cadence; and the third, with a more agogic character, follows a perfect cadence [d'Indy, 1909, p.272].

4.3.2 Caplin's Analysis

In his paper "The Expanded Cadential Progression," Caplin labels the section starting at m. 47 (d'Indy's third element of Transition) as the subordinate theme without justifying but simply asserting it, shown in 4.6. The subordinate theme is identified as a significantly expanded sentential structure, featuring two expanded presentation phrases occurring consecutively. This repetition draws parallels with d'Indy's repeated generative period. Both presentation and generative periods serve as initiating units, typically appear once but, in this case, are repeated in succession.

Figure 4.4: Entry - mm. 17-34

-VD: First element of P

-WC: Part 1 of $\boxed{\text{TR}}$?

Figure 4.5: Entry - mm. 35-46

-VD: Second element of P

-WC: Part 2 of $\boxed{\text{TR}}$?

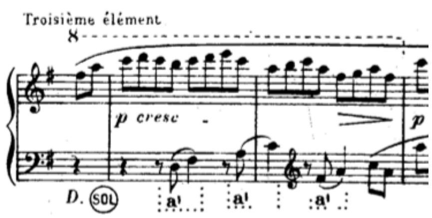

Figure 4.6: Entry - mm. 47-63

-VD: Third element of P

-WC: Compound Presentation of $\boxed{\text{ST}}$

Figure 4.7: Entry - mm. 63-74

-VD: First Phrase of B

-WC: Continuation in $\boxed{\text{ST}}$

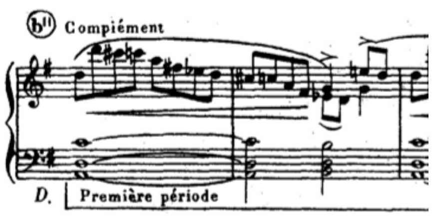

Figure 4.8: Entry - mm. 75-100

-VD: Second Phrase of B

-WC: ECP of $\boxed{\text{ST}}$

Figure 4.9: Entry - mm. 100-123b

-VD: Third Phrase of B

-WC: Closing Section of $\boxed{\text{ST}}$

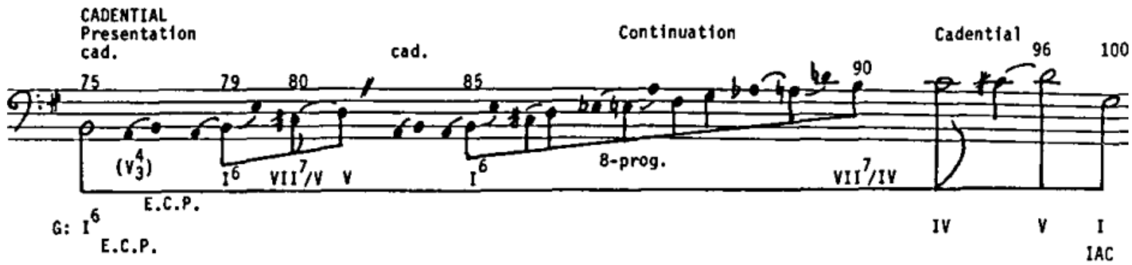

Figure 4.10: Bassline sketch of the expanded cadential progression [Caplin, 1987, p. 242].

A large continuation section begins in m. 63 (d'Indy's first phrase of the second idea), shown in 4.7, with a new four-measure antecedent-like phrase, which briefly modulates to the dominant region, confirmed by a perfect authentic cadence in m. 66. This antecedent fulfills a genuine continuational function due to its fragmentation relative to the repeated eight-measure presentation and the marked acceleration in harmonic change. This new phrase begins to be repeated like a consequent but becomes fragmented through sequential repetitions in m. 70 and further in m. 74, leading to a I6 chord where the expanded cadential progression (ECP) begins.

This first-inversion tonic, sustained by accented neighboring chords in measures 75-78, initiates the expanded cadential progression, shown in 4.8 and corresponding to d'Indy's second phrase of the second idea. This progression is interrupted by an evaded cadence on m. 81, followed by another nested and expanded sentence, ultimately culminating in a final imperfect authentic cadence on m. 101. A subsequent closing section (d'Indy's third phrase of the second idea), shown in 4.8, ends the exposition on m. 126.

4.3.3 Discussion

The passage in mm. 63-76, where d'Indy identifies the beginning of the second musical idea, Caplin instead labels it as part of a continuation. Caplin's analysis characterizes this continuation section as containing a nested period, complete with a cadence closing the antecedent. While this interpretation appears to contradict Caplin's theoretical framework—which states that "the sentence form has no cadential articulation prior to its closing cadence" [Caplin, 2004, p. 58]—it may instead reflect a deliberate sacrifice of theoretical strictness. Here, Caplin seems to overturn his own principles in favor of a more flexible and creative analysis, adapting his theory to account for the complexities of the music rather than forcing the music to conform rigidly to the theory.

Vincent d'Indy's perspective on the exposition in Beethoven's "Hammerklavier" Sonata, Op. 106, differs notably from William Caplin's analysis, but aligns more closely with the views of other scholars such as Sterling Lambert, who posits that

> the transition passage [on mm. 47-63] simply prolongs this dominant by means of a descending melodic turn at measure 47, prior to a cadence in G major (m. 63) that ushers in the first theme of the second group. [Lambert, 2008, p. 450]

He suggests that this passage acts more as a preparatory section, delaying the arrival of the subordinate theme and thus contributing to the sense of temporal suspension and indeterminacy. Besides, David Greene also supports this analysis but by objecting Caplin's interpretation. He argues that,

> If G were established as a tonic before these paired phrases (47–63) began, [these paired phrases] would be analogous to the second theme in other movements. But instead, [these paired phrases] serve to tonicize G, in order that the pair of subphrases in bars 63–66 and 67ff. may function as a second theme. [Greene, 1982]

Green's articulation is implicit but aligns with d'Indy's interpretation, where he states,

> This third element, which ends the bridge, is merely a long melodic line over the dominant of the key of G, replacing that of G minor, and producing a very noticeable increase in brightness. [d'Indy, 1909, p. 268, *translation mine*]

Both Greene and d'Indy favor theme arrivals that coincide with the establishment of the local tonic harmony and view tonicizations as belonging to pre-thematic content. However, d'Indy introduces an additional layer of analogy by connecting the harmonic shift to a perceived increase in "brightness," thereby adding a more expressive dimension to the formal interpretation.

4.4 Conclusion

By introducing perspectives of various scholars, it becomes evident that d'Indy's approach to the "Hammerklavier" Sonata's exposition aligns more closely with the broader scholarly consensus.

While Caplin's analysis provides a detailed structural breakdown, it is met with significant counterarguments, and it might be due to his objective to find cadential progression that is expanded for discussion. Given that expanded section extends 25-measure long from mm. 75-100, the presentation and continuation phrases are expected to be proportionally expanded, leading to an elongated subordinate theme section. This necessity might require Caplin to reach over to earlier materials, leading to the inclusion of the content from mm. 47-63 within the elongated sentential structure. His approach of embedding cadences within an expanded presentation phrase reflects a process in which he prioritizes one theoretical perspective while temporarily sacrificing the strict adherence to another.

D'Indy's interpretation is not constrained by the need to fit a preconceived theoretical model. Although d'Indy engages in existential discussions about musical ideas, his analytical choices remain largely independent of these overarching theories. This separation allows for greater stability and flexibility in his analysis, making it less prone to the interpretative issues that arise when theory takes precedence over the music itself.

In conclusion, Caplin's analysis is theory-oriented, as he works within an existing theoretical framework and occasionally sacrifices aspects of that framework to fit the example at hand. In contrast, d'Indy adopts an example-oriented approach, building his theoretical insights directly from the music itself. While Caplin prioritizes adapting theory to accommodate the example, d'Indy allows the example to embody and shape the theory, resulting in an analysis that feels more grounded in the music and less constrained by external theoretical structures.